The Congress is also aspiring to gain seats in Telangana where it defeated the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) in the assembly polls last year. In 2019, the BRS (in its older TRS avatar) had won nine of its 17 seats, the BJP four, the Congress three and the AIMIM (All-India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen) one. With the BRS going through a meltdown, the election in Telangana has become a direct battle between the Congress and the BJP. "This is a challenge for the Grand Old Party," says Amitabh Tiwari. "When the main opponent is the BJP, the Congress has a tendency to flounder. Besides, their leaders easily get compromised."

In Andhra Pradesh, I.N.D.I.A. lost a potential ally when Chandrababu Naidu's Telugu Desam Party (TDP) chose to tie up with the BJP. The Congress has always been a rival of Chief Minister Jagan Mohan Reddy's YSRCP (Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party) and has enlisted the chief minister's sister Y.S. Sharmila to spearhead its campaign in the state. In this triangular tussle, any upsurge in Congress fortunes will mean a split in the anti-NDA vote, indirectly helping the rival alliance. Even so, Sharmila's decision to contest the Lok Sabha election instead of the assembly one, which is also scheduled around the same time, demonstrates that the Congress is unwilling to cede ground in a province that played a key role in its return to power at the Centre in 2009.

SEARCHING FOR A LEADER

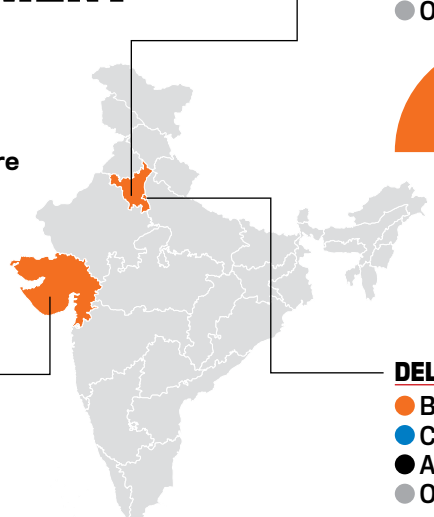
While Prime Minister Modi's leadership is seen as decisive and driving India in a particular direction, the Opposition camp is seen as an unstable conglomeration of aspirants often driven by their own personal or parochial agendas. "People see Modi as a decisive leader who has delivered in terms of development and commitment to ideological promises,"



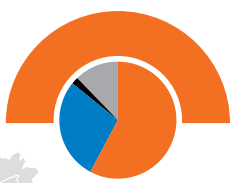
CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

THE NEW EXPERIMENT

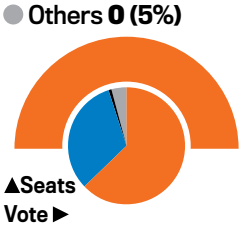
The AAP and the Congress have forged a pre-poll alliance in these three states, where the BJP made a clean sweep with over 50 per cent vote share in 2019



HARYANA 10
- BJP **10** (58%)
- Cong **0** (28%)
- AAP **0** (0.4%)
- Others **0** (13.6%)



GUJARAT 26
- BJP **26** (62%)
- Cong **0** (32%)
- AAP **0** (1%)
- Others **0** (5%)



DELHI 7
- BJP **7** (57%)
- Cong **0** (23%)
- AAP **0** (18%)
- Others **0** (2%)



▲Seats
Vote ► share

SEATS WON IN LS 2019
(Vote share %)
● Total Seats